



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Panamanian Doctor Pleads Guilty in Criminal Fraud Case Expected to Save U.S. Government \$25M

Tuesday, April 15, 2025

For Immediate Release

Office of Public Affairs

Based on assistance provided by the United States, Panamanian authorities have obtained a criminal plea from Dr. Rolando Chin, a surgeon residing in Panama, in connection with a widespread fraud scheme perpetrated against the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) by Dr. Chin and others in Panama.

The Department of Justice, the Department of State, and VA initially uncovered rampant fraud perpetrated by various medical doctors and pharmacies in Panama making claims to the VA's Foreign Medical Program (FMP), which supports vital medical care for U.S. veterans living abroad. The agencies found evidence that Panamanian doctors and pharmacies were submitting false and inflated claims to the FMP, including claims for services never rendered or medicines never received, as well as deceptive billing for services performed.

"The Department is committed to combating fraud against the United States wherever such conduct occurs," said Acting Assistant Attorney General Yaakov Roth of the Justice Department's Civil Division. "Our efforts in this case have not only recovered funds on behalf of the American taxpayers, but have also prevented significant future losses. We are grateful to our Panamanian colleagues for their ongoing cooperation and collaboration in this matter."

In December 2022, the United States filed a criminal complaint with Public Ministry of Panama against almost 40 Panamanian defendants, including doctors, pharmacies, corporations, and a hospital, for aggravated fraud and money laundering. Working closely with the Department of Justice, Panamanian prosecutors subsequently initiated an investigation, and in August 2023, brought the first set of formal charges based on the U.S. complaint. Earlier this year, the Panamanian prosecutors successfully obtained the first guilty plea from Dr. Chin to certain fraud charges, which led to a contemporaneous restitution agreement with the United States. Panamanian prosecutors are continuing to pursue proceedings against the other indicted individuals, as well as their investigation of the other defendants named in the U.S. complaint.

Following the United States’ filing of its complaint in Panama, the VA instituted a government-wide suspension of the defendants, which took effect in August 2024. As a result of this suspension, the VA projected that its FMP expenditures in Panama for Fiscal Year 2025 will be cut in half from the previous year. This represents a projected savings of almost \$25 million.

This ongoing matter is a coordinated effort between the Department of Justice’s Office of Foreign Litigation (OFL) and the VA, with support from the VA Office of Inspector General, as well as the U.S. Department of State. OFL’s Attorney-in-Charge of Latin American Litigation Christine Brennan and Assistant Director Kiesha Minyard are handling the case.

Updated July 3, 2025

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